

a number in chess.

Among these prodigies, Mendonca had a stellar start to the year. He clinched the 2024 Tata Steel Challengers event, a tournament that featured a mix of seasoned veterans and rising talents, including Erwin l'Ami, Hans Niemann, Anton Korobov, Salem Saleh, Divya, and Harika. His triumph secured him a coveted spot in the 2025 Masters event.

Pranav's 18th year was equally remarkable. The 2022 Under-16 World Youth Olympiad gold medallist, Pranav bagged another gold, this time at the FIDE World Youth U-18 Open Rapid. He finished with an impressive 9.5/11 in the Rapid and scored 19.5/22 in the Blitz event.

He also won the Challenger section of the Chennai Grand Masters, earning himself a spot in the 2025 Masters event of the tournament.

Divya added her share of brilliance, complementing her double Olympiad gold with a victory at the 2024 World Junior Girls' Championship, held on home soil in Gandhinagar. Her exceptional performances throughout the year elevated her to India's No. 2 in women's rankings, trailing only Humpy, and brought her closer to achieving the GM title.

While the teenagers dominated headlines, a 25-year-old calmly carved his path to the elite. Aravindh Chithambaram had a phenomenal year, gaining 66.9 Elo points — the highest among all players in the world's top 30. With a live rating of 2728.9, Aravindh surged past renowned names such as Anish Giri, Richard Rapport, Daniil Dubov, and Vidit, cementing his place among chess's elite.

Veteran brilliance

And just when it seemed the year belonged entirely to prodigies, the 37-year-old Humpy reminded everyone of her enduring brilliance by clinching gold at the Women's World Rapid Championship.

India's best female chess player for over two decades, Humpy showcased her class and experience in New York, defeating Indonesia's Irine Kharisma Sukandar in the final round to secure her second World Rapid title.

IN 2025...

The Ding vs Gukesh World Championship marked the first time two Asians competed for the chess crown. With seven spots still open for the 2026 Candidates, the possibility of two Indians vying for the title is growing. Arjun, who narrowly missed qualifying via FIDE Circuit Ratings, aims for a comeback with opportunities through the 2025 World Cup, FIDE Grand Swiss, Circuit Ratings, and rating averages from August 2025 to January 2026.

The World Cup's knockout format will be a key event, with Praggnanandhaa aiming to replicate his 2023 success. However, matching or surpassing 2024's achievements will be a challenge.

Meanwhile, Magnus Carlsen's push for freestyle chess, emphasising creativity over opening theory, is gaining momentum. The 2025 Freestyle Chess Tour, including New Delhi, reflects this shift. Tensions between chess elites and FIDE continue, highlighting the evolving dynamics of the sport as traditional structures face growing dissatisfaction.